

A Sky So Dark
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They had found the perfect spot. A hill overlooking a small lake. A small fishing shack to the right a couple of hundred feet that looked like it hadn't been used in centuries. The only sounds around were of crickets and frogs out in the distance. Not a city around for miles. They parked the truck and got out.

Matthew set out a quilt at the top of the hill and went back to grab a few snacks out of the truck. Jasper had set down the map and was rifling through the back seats looking for the two sets of binoculars and the telescope. She brought them out and laid them out on the quilt, then set up the telescope on its tripod and set it down in the grass next to the quilt. By the time she was done, Matthew was walking back to the spot on the hill. He paused and looked at the fishing shack. The door was ajar.

"Think there's anyone hiding in there?"

She rolled her eyes. "Jesus, you're paranoid." She paused. "You didn't forget the drinks, right?"

"Like hell I would."

He found a flat spot among the grass next to the quilt and set the two beers down. IPAs he'd stolen from his dad's fridge. His mom had promised to cover for the two of them while his dad was asleep. He set the sandwiches next to the beers, and next to the sandwiches he set a small lantern.

"Shit, I almost forgot the chart." He started to stand up.

"Dude, trust me, we don't need it. The sky is right there."

"I suppose, but how do we know what we're looking for? There's so much to see."

"Exactly, you egghead. We just use our eyes. And those." She pointed to the binoculars and then to the telescope. "It's not that hard."

He sat back down and let out a sigh. He grabbed one of the sets of binoculars and laid on his back, looking at the night sky. He fidgeted with the binoculars for a moment. He hadn't used one of these in years. Jasper took the other pair, took off the lens covers, and put them to her eyes. Matthew glanced over and did the same.

Neither of them spoke a word for the next thirty minutes. They laid there looking at the night sky. At some point, Matthew sat up and grabbed a beer and one of the sandwiches they had brought. A turkey and provolone he had made the night prior, along with Jasper's grilled cheese, which she also eventually took, along with the other beer. She didn't mind a cold grilled cheese. It reminded her of her youth.

Matthew set the binoculars down and looked around. The lake was quiet. He looked over at the fishing shack. He tried to convince himself that the door was more open than it was before, but he knew it wasn't. He looked at Jasper, her eyes still glued to the lenses of the binoculars. She likes doing this kind of thing much more than me, he thought to himself. He breathed in, then out, then laid back down and looked through his set again. He looked for a good minute, then lowered them again. "Did that star just go out?"

Jasper continued to look through her binoculars. She seemed unphased. "What do you mean?"

He sat for a moment, his eyes looking at nothing in particular. "I swear I was just looking at a star, and then a moment later it was gone. Just not there anymore."

Jasper lowered her binoculars and slowly looked over at him. "That shouldn't be possible. Did anything happen before it was gone? Any kind of burst of light or anything?"

"Nope. It just faded out, and then it was gone."

"Weird. Maybe it was a satellite or something." She put the binoculars back up to her eyes and started looking again. After a few minutes she set them back down. "No way."

"What?"

"I just saw one disappear, too."

Both of them put down the binoculars and looked at each other with puzzled expressions, gears turning in their heads. Not a word was said between them. After another couple of minutes, they saw another star fade, and then another. Matthew was the first to break the silence.

"What the hell is going on?" He turned his head and looked over at Jasper expectantly, like he wanted her to solve all of this with her college-level understanding of astronomy. It looked like his eyes had widened slightly, but it was hard for Jasper to tell with the limited lighting. All she could do was look back at him, her expression barely changing from before.

"You know, I really don't know. This is the weirdest thing I've ever seen." She paused for a moment. "Maybe we're in a collective dream or something. Or drunk."

Matthew sat up upon hearing this. "For one: we had one beer each. We're not drunk. And two: you're not concerned at all with the fact that we just witnessed multiple stars in the sky disappear? Fully disappear?" He was starting to sound agitated. "What's next? The sky starts falling apart and reveals none of reality is real?" He put his hands to his head and looked down toward the ground.

Jasper let out a sigh. "And? There isn't really anything we can do right now. Who's to say this isn't a dream?" She lets loose a slight smile, both at the thought of such an interesting dream and in the hopes of calming Matthew down, but it doesn't seem to work. "Ok, I'll admit, this is probably cause for alarm, but, again, there isn't much we can do about it. We're miles away from any form of civilization. Even if we went to tell someone, by that point people would probably already know."

Matthew thought for a moment. "What if we're the only ones who have seen this? What if this is the end of the world and we're the only ones who know about it?" Jasper almost heard a whimper in his voice.

A few moments passed by as Jasper thought about her response. "If we are, then that's something special. If we aren't, then that means we aren't alone." She had started to feel more and more dread as she thought more about the situation, but it was enough to calm both of them down for a couple short moments before they both started looking through their sets of binoculars again.

More stars had disappeared. The sky looked like one often seen in larger cities, where light pollution made many stars invisible, except that they could still see the rest of the galaxy. As they laid down and continued to watch, they saw even more stars fading, and both of them started to panic.

Matthew's breathing quickened, which Jasper could hear, and made her adrenaline spike. She immediately set the binoculars down and stood up and began pacing in a circle, not

saying anything but having several clashing thoughts within her head. She had realized that while Matthew might have been taking what they saw too far within his mind, she had not taken it far enough, and was now doing whatever she could to calm herself after the truth of the situation had caught up with her. She regularly stopped pacing to take deep breaths, but it wasn't helping much.

Matthew, on the other hand, sank deeper into himself. He curled up into a ball and his face started to become wet with tears. He rocked back and forth, telling himself that this wasn't happening, as though it would change anything. He thought about his life until that point. He thought about all the moments he regretted, and all the moments he wished he could relive. He thought that maybe this was all a test given to him by some unseen entity to see if his life had been truly worth living.

Jasper thought about the finality of what she was seeing as she continued to pace, her hands going from her sides to across her chest to back at her sides. The stars weren't reappearing, and they likely never would. Maybe this was the end of the world, or even the universe. There was so much she hadn't done, so much more life she could live, and there was a strong possibility that it would be cut short tonight.

Matthew sat curled up for several minutes before collecting himself. He laid back down for a moment and then sat back up again, his face blotchy from dried tears. He looked at the telescope that they hadn't used all night and picked it up and looked through it. Up close, the stars looked like they were, in fact, fading out of existence, like a lightbulb slowly burning out, or finishing the last page in a book. It was beautiful in a way.

He thought about how small they were in the face of an event like this. Two kids, not even old enough to legally drink, and all they could do was watch. He set the telescope down, preferring to see the last of the cosmos without the use of instruments.

Jasper stopped pacing for a moment and saw him looking at the sky, and she looked, too. With her eyes unaided she saw that most of the stars in the sky had left, with only a couple of dozen remaining. Together they looked and together they saw stars fading one by one, until only the pinks and blues and greens of the Milky Way could be seen. Tears started to stream down Jasper's face, and she smiled as she saw the gases of the galaxy start to slowly disperse and diffuse, and then they were gone, and only an inky black sky remained. Yeah. Maybe this is ok, she thought. As long as we're here, maybe things are ok.

She laid down, and Matthew followed. Together, they sat and looked at a sky so dark it might as well have not existed. They didn't need words. They didn't need anything else. They laid and waited and waited for the sun to rise, but it never did.